chief minister. Deshmukh told my *Maharashtra Times* colleague Prakash Akolkar and myself how Pawar, with the backing of a few senior Congress leaders, planned to make a bid for the top job. Apparently, a meeting had been held in a south Delhi hotel where Pawar had promised to financially support potential Congress MPs in their election campaign in return for endorsing him as the party's prime ministerial candidate. 'The strategy is all in place. Pawar is ready for the final push,' Deshmukh said.

We rushed to the office to file the story. It was a slow news day. The news editor decided to carry it as a bottom spread on the front page of the *Times of India*. Delhi's power brokers were thrown into a tizzy when the story broke the next morning. Sitting in Mumbai, we had no idea our story would change political equations in Delhi. At midnight, I got a call from Pawar himself. 'How could you print such a story? Do you know the damage it has caused me?' he said angrily. And before I could calm him down, came the punchline. 'Don't you want to see a Maharashtrian as prime minister?!'

A few weeks later, Pawar was edged out in his attempt to be prime minister by P.V. Narasimha Rao. The Congress's old order had united to stall Pawar's hopes. Though the NCP leader is not the kind of politician to bear grudges for long, I don't think he ever forgave me. It only convinced me just how desperate Pawar was to move, as one Maharashtra journalist once put it, 'from the Sahyadris to the Himalayas'.

Pawar did try again to conquer Delhi, a task which had eluded the Marathas since the defeat in the third battle of Panipat in 1761. He took on Sonia Gandhi over her foreign origins in 1999. It was a period when Pawar as the party's Lok Sabha leader sensed a vacuum in the Congress and was itching to take control. Sonia had been party president for less than a year and was vulnerable to an internal rebellion. Just ahead of his 'revolt' against Sonia, he had met a few of us and hinted that the Congress needed a new leadership. 'We need mass-based leaders to get the Congress back on track,' he claimed. But he had miscalculated the Congress's loyalty quotient for the Gandhi family. Most of the top leaders in the party chose to stand by Sonia. He later claimed that he was not against Sonia as Congress president but